Session 18

2025-08-10

1 - Silent darkness

~20:00, 10 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The lights have not come back. Kaelthar is stable on the ground, unconscious with the field dressing just barely holding him, and Nyx puts one of her berries into his mouth — the paladin stirs awake, still groggy. The camp fires are out and so is the mood, merchants and guards on cold dry rations, the caravan subdued around the ring.
2. Amidamaru crosses to the suspected cultist carts to speak with the guard who had come to the wisp fight and finds he is in fact a driver. Bloodied, he sits near them, and another driver presses a handkerchief into his hands for his wounds.
3. When Amidamaru asks what he would rather see done with the captured bandits — dead or free — the driver answers it is none of his business while they are not with the caravan, and he would not condone killing unarmed men; Amidamaru and Nyx read him as lying to keep up a civil front — the driver would rather see them dead.
4. Having whispered the plan to Nuberroca earlier, Amidamaru summons a small illusion of a wisp near the goliath. Nuberroca sells the panic, and **Sulesdeg** comes tearing in with a sword nearly the size of the goliath's — the blade cuts through the fake wisp and buries itself in the ground, and the guards raise their crossbows around the ring.
5. As the dust settles, Amidamaru overhears one of the cultists mutters that they should not trust the blue giant — the muttering guard's face registers as faintly familiar. Claws out, he rounds on them: how could they speak that way of the people saving their skins day after day? They had not fought the bandits or the wisps; when the trolls came, they would beg on their knees to be saved, and then they would see who saved them. He throws the handkerchief back in the guard's face.
6. Nuberroca steps up aggressively, and some cultist aim their crossbows at him. Amidamaru holds the goliath back — only uncultured and intolerant people — and when he presses that they had not even fought the bandits, one guard admits he had been there, pinning the familiarity.
7. The party settles for sleep; Eguzkilore takes the first four hours on his elven trance, which lets the rest of the party sleep uninterrupted and earns him some goodwill with the caravan's watch.

2 - Exotic feathers

~08:30, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The night passes without incident. Nuberroca's fever lifts on the long rest. Amidamaru wakes earlier than the rest to burn incense and re-cast the ritual that calls **Munin** — the owl the wisps killed the night before. The caravan drivers keep well clear of what may or may not be hallucinogenic. Party sets out shortly after.
2. Perhaps an hour on the road, a bird crosses the sky against their line of march — long tail, red chest, blue and yellow wings, nothing anyone at the caravan has seen before and plainly the most beautiful bird any of them have ever seen in their lives. Sulesdeg raises his crossbow and takes the bird down with two bolts. The exotic bird is lugged into his wagon in a bloody heap.
3. A second bird — this one green — crosses at greater range some time later. Sulesdeg tries again but the shot is too long; the bolt goes wide. A third time, a flock of small birds boils up from behind a rise ahead and streams away over the wagons. Nyx takes it as a warning — when things fall out of the ordinary in this world, there is always a reason, and the reason is rarely a good one. She asks **Lai** whether the caravan can spare the time to check; he warns that stopping costs them their next camping-place. She goes forward alone anyway, and Amidamaru sends Munin overhead to shadow her.

3 - The bird merchant

~11:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Cresting the rise, Nyx sees an overturned wagon defended by a handful of guards and one man in richer clothing — arrows still coming from a scatter of goblinoids around them, and a bugbear closing in to hammer the wagon between crossbow volleys. She hides and reads the field; there are several of them, and the shapes are hobgoblins, bugbears, and goblins in mixed cover. Amidamaru and Eguzkilore catch up on her steps and drop into cover.
2. Nyx opens with a shot to distract the pressure on the wagon — the arrow lands, and she calls out for the goblinoids to stop attacking and run, because a serious contingent is on its way and they are in trouble. The answer the goblinoids give is to turn on the party; a bugbear closes on Amidamaru, grabs him and drags him toward the rest without apparent effort.
3. Amidamaru sings up the shadow-blade and takes the bugbear on the spot — the strike lands, leaving a thunder reverberation waiting to crack on the creature. Nyx swaps her focus from a dying hobgoblin to a fresh target across the field, and the arrows keep finding shoulders and throats. From deeper in the goblinoid line, a heavier hobgoblin barks orders.
4. The party allies come up over the rise — a few of the caravan guards and the suspected cultists put arrows across the field at the bugbear nearest to Amidamaru, drawing blood but not dropping it.
5. Nyx takes a poisoned bolt to the shoulder and holds it — she can feel the poison burning across her skin — keeping the mark on her target through the pain. Kaelthar manages to join the fight; still too far for a javelin, so he uses his crossbow while closing in.
6. ***[EPIC]*** When the hobgoblin captain finally turns to run, Eguzkilore drives through a second volley of shots and puts three arrows into his running back — the fourth catches him as he falls. The rest of the hobgoblins fall back in disciplined formation, covering each other in leapfrog — a trained, heavily-militarised line, nothing like the goblins' panic — and the party holds fire as they clear.

4 - Oyn Evenmor

1. Three battered guards and the man in the fine coat come out from under the wagon: **Oyn Evenmor**, an exotic-bird merchant bound for Waterdeep, who bows and thanks the party for his life. Nyx introduces the party by name; Nuberroca and the rest catch up. Oyn admits he should have hired the Company of the Boar when they offered at the last tavern and did not, and he has lost most of his cargo — the cages sit open with dead birds inside or empty on the road.
2. Amidamaru magically mends some cages and casts a healing spell into each of the three guards, one after another. Oyn presses three coins of gold into Nyx's hand and closes her fingers over them — she reads it as light payment for the man's obvious wealth, but does not press.
3. ***[EPIC]*** Oyn thinks to ask after his birds. Nuberroca answers, straight-faced, that one of their own caravan has already caught one, and points at Sulesdeg. Sulesdeg produces the plucked, bloodied bird from the wagon on demand. Oyn's face goes rabid, then collapses; he sinks halfway to the ground before recovering, and rises telling the guard he is the worst person he has ever met, with the most twisted humour he has ever seen, undeserving of the air he breathes — that was the most valuable bird he carried. He turns his back and tells his own guards to hurry the repair.
4. Amidamaru buys two broken metal birdcages off Oyn — filigree wire, good for tinkering. He also asks a guard whether they have crossed anything strange on the road behind them: no, only the usual traffic, no cloaked strangers, and about four or five groups making toward Waterdeep.
5. Eguzkilore searches the hobgoblin captain — a longbow and a half-plate that the heroes mend and keep. The party recovers some arrows and lifts several poisoned shafts from the hobgoblins, then search the bodies for valuables, retrieving some silver coins.

5 – The wayside tavern

~20:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. As evening comes on, the caravan reaches a wayside inn on the road — *El Reposo en el Camino*, an undefended roadhouse with one tavern-keeper, **Olver**, who greets the party and offers rooms, food, and repair. Nyx pays a gold for a shared upstairs room with Mialee, then buys a round of beer for the six. The others share rooms, except Amidamaru who will sleep outside in his shell against the autumn cold.
2. A second party is already at the tavern — a table of four humans, warily eating: a barbarian in furs, a rogue in finer dress, a paladin with the trappings of a religious order, and a warlock at the back. Their leader climbs up on his own table and announces the company to the assembled merchants as **Jorath Vexundar**, famed leader of the *Company of the Boar* and slayer of villains without number; the paladin **Kaldan Voss**, who felled the lich of the Fields of Death; the warlock **Thorvin Caldorath**, who alone brought down a mountain giant with his magic; and the barbarian **Khorvalis**, the strongest of all time — a hire-on-the-spot pitch.
3. Nyx climbs onto Nuberroca's shoulders and answers back with her own, naming herself **Nyx Tukog** and the party the *Company of the Roe deer*, listing the wisps and the bandits and adding, small, that she had not even wet herself over the trolls — and gets no applause, since everyone already knew her.
4. At a separate table sit three wealthy travelers: a knight in armour, a mage in strange robes, and a nobleman. Kaelthar asks after the blazon he saw on their wagon; the noble brushes him off and, once Kaelthar is far enough away, whispers something in the knight's ear that the paladin cannot catch.
5. Nyx presses Jorath on the trolls — the Company of the Boar is credited with a good count of them — and Jorath prices the answer at one piece of gold. Nyx pays; Jorath draws her close and whispers the trick, then reveals a pendant against his chest with a very large tusk.
6. Nuberroca wanders across to the Company of the Boar's table and challenges Khorvalis to a pre-dinner brawl — *"¿te gustaría que nos pegáramos unas hostias?"*. Khorvalis declines — he reserves his strength for real enemies. When the trolls come up in Nyx's question and Khorvalis reckons them bigger than Nuberroca, the goliath invokes his people's gift and enlarges himself in answer. Khorvalis stays where he is — he does not use dirty tricks like magic to look stronger or to frighten his companions. Sulesdeg's beer falls over from the shock of the size-shift.

6 – The chest in the cart

~22:00, 11 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Mialee has been laying a plan through the dinner: she casts a silent image of herself at her table, and Amidamaru turns the elf invisible over the copy. The double stays at the table doing the small motions of a conversation while the rogue, unseen, slips out to the yard where the wagons are parked. Olver, at the door, sees the door open and close and mutters about the strong winds.
2. Nyx catches enough of the nobles' conversation at the other table to know they are in a hurry to Waterdeep — their cargo is beginning to spoil. The nobles rise and climb to their private room upstairs; Nuberroca, back in his normal size, follows and is pushed out at the door by the knight — through the closed door he catches talk of plebeians who could never amount to much, and the words *cursed mutants*.
3. Mialee reaches the cultist wagon and works her lockpicks on a chest inside, taking long enough that the illusory copy of herself at the table blinks out, causing a stir in the room, though she is still invisible on the way back and returns to her chair without being seen. What she found she keeps to herself, simply saying that there are people around and this is no safe place to talk.
4. As the party turns in for the night, a sudden heavy rain breaks over the roof and does not let up — Amidamaru keeps to his shell outside through the full of it.